HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

Calmness & When to Show Anger: HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem, Chapter 6

Given Monday 13 April 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem

Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Kifayat al-Abidin) — Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam
Chapter: Perek 6 (אריכות אפים — Slow to Anger / Calmness) — Conclusion **Edition:** Feldheim

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Recap: Chapters 1–6 (Part 1)

- **Chapter 1:** Two paths — the Tzaddik (basics) and the Chasid (beyond). No point being a Chasid without the basics.
- **Chapter 2:** All middot are interrelated — working on one affects others.
- **Chapter 3:** Purity of motive — four levels, from social pressure (lowest) to serving because Hashem commanded (highest).
- **Chapter 4:** Rachamanut (compassion) — first of the 13 Attributes. Important, but sometimes cruelty is necessary. When in doubt → choose mercy.
- **Chapter 5:** Nedivut (generosity) — giving with no obligation. Four kinds: money, influence, intellect, faith. Avraham modeled all four.
- **Chapter 6 (Part 1):** Calmness ≠ apathy. Intellect must control emotion. Anger = drunkenness. Anger + arrogance go together; patience + humility go together. Training Method 1: stories from Torah (negative examples — Kayin, Eisav, the brothers, Moshe at Mei Merivah, Shaul, David). Training Method 2: Torah's mitzvot designed to prevent anger.

Training Through Stories: Positive Examples of Calmness

1. Reuven — Calming the Brothers

- The brothers wanted to kill Yosef
- Reuven intervened: "Throw him into this pit instead"
- Reuven's plan: calm them down first, then bring Yosef home
- Result: Yosef wasn't killed — only sold
- Reuven used calmness to de-escalate

2. Yosef — Forgiving His Brothers

- The **first place in Torah** where someone forgives
- After Yaakov dies → the brothers are afraid → they make up a story that Yaakov told them to ask for forgiveness
- Yosef says: don't worry, it was all from Hashem

- He could have used his power and anger → but he recognized the yichud Hashem (everything comes from God)
- He was willing to overlook what they did

3. Shaul — Forgiving Those Who Disrespected Him

ויאמר שאול לא יומת איש ביום הזה כי היום עשה ה' תשועה בישראל

- People of Yavesh Gilad wanted to surrender to Nachash king of Ammon
- Hashem made a miracle and they were saved
- Some people demanded execution: "They were willing to surrender!"
- Shaul said: no one will be killed today — Hashem has given us victory
- Willing to forgo personal honour

4. David — Not Killing Shaul

- Shaul tried to kill David multiple times
- David had the opportunity to kill Shaul — didn't do it
- Just cut his coat as a hint: "I could have killed you but didn't"
- Shaul's response: צדיק אתה ממני — "You are more righteous than I"

5. David — Not Punishing Shim'i ben Gera

- Shim'i ben Gera publicly cursed and denigrated David HaMelech
- David said: הניחו לו ויקלל — "Leave him, let him curse"
- Later, when Shim'i came to apologize at the Jordan → David forgave him and swore not to kill him
- **But:** At the end of his life, David commanded Shlomo to execute Shim'i

Why the contradiction?

- This was not personal revenge — it was **halachic obligation**
- A Talmid Chacham who is publicly disgraced — the Gemara debates whether he can forgive
- But a **king, nasi, or leader** — the Torah does NOT allow them to forgo their honour
- David felt the timing wasn't right during his lifetime → left it to Shlomo
- Proof: David writes in Tehillim that he didn't take personal revenge → the command to Shlomo was din, not nekama

The Chachamim on Calmness

לעולם יהא אדם ענוותן כהלל ואל יהא קפדן כשמאי

- Always be humble like Hillel, don't be strict like Shammai

עלובין ואינן עולבין שומעין חרפתן ואינן משיבין

- Those who sanctify Hashem's name: hear their disgrace and do not respond
  they don't even feel it inside — such a high level that it doesn't affect them = עלובין
- Hashem loves such people: ואוהביו כצאת השמש בגבורתו

לעולם יהא אדם רך כקנה ואל יהא קשה כארז

- Be soft like a reed, not hard like a cedar

- That's why we write a Sefer Torah with a quill made from a **reed** (kaneh) — it's soft, flexible, not stubborn

כל המעביר על מידותיו מעבירין לו על כל פשעיו

- A person who overlooks the wrongdoing of others → Hashem overlooks their wrongdoing
- "Who does He forgive? The one who forgives others"

Calmness Is on the Path to Prophecy

אריכות אפיים היא מתכונות הנבואה

- A person who is truly calm is on the way to reaching a high level of prophecy
- It is also one of the attributes of Hashem Himself

Training Through Mitzvot: Commandments Designed to Prevent Anger

1. Arei Miklat — Cities of Refuge

פן ירדוף גואל הדם אחרי הרוצח כי יחם לבבו

- Purpose: let everyone calm down
- The relative of the accidentally killed person may be so angry they can't control themselves
- Torah says: go to the city of refuge, a safe space — let emotions settle
- The Rambam in Moreh Nevuchim says the same: arei miklat = a designated place to allow people to cool down
- Stays there until the Kohen Gadol dies → only then can he come out

2. Mitzvat Tochachah — Rebuking Your Fellow

הוכח תוכיח את עמיתך ולא תשא עליו חטא

Two understandings of this pasuk:

a) The Gemara's reading: When you rebuke someone, don't do it publicly (that would be bearing a sin — embarrassing them). Take them aside privately.

b) The second reading (Rishonim + Rambam in Hilchot De'ot): Tell someone when they've wronged you — don't harbor the upset within yourself.

ולא תשא עליו חטא = don't carry the sin/wrongdoing inside you

- Many people harbor displeasure within themselves → the Torah says: speak it out
- Rambam: מצוה עליו להודיעו — "It is a mitzvah to tell him: why did you do this to me?"
- When you speak it out → you release the negativity from within yourself

3. Lo Tikom V'Lo Titor — Don't Take Revenge, Don't Harbor

- The Torah prohibits revenge because revenge = exercising emotional anger
- Working on calmness → you won't come to revenge
- Netira (harboring) also prohibited — even if you don't act, the simmering is destructive

4. Don't Curse a Judge, Leader, or Deaf Person

- Aside from the terrible act of cursing → these prohibitions help a person not lose control of emotions
- The Rambam in Sefer HaMitzvot: the prohibition stems from the Torah wanting us to control our emotions
- When a person curses → they've lost control

5. Don't Hit Anyone

- We learn from Ki Tetzei: it's forbidden to hit someone beyond what's required
- Whether another person or a parent (even worse punishment for parents)
- Rabbi Avraham: the reason = you're losing control of your emotions, getting angry, not being calm

6. Don't Blaspheme

- A person who curses Hashem → stems from lack of emotional control

7. Helping Your Enemy's Donkey

כי תראה חמור שונאך רובץ תחת משאו... עזוב תעזוב עמו

- Simple meaning: "You must help him" (the verb can mean "to help")
- **Targum Onkelos reads differently:** עזוב = leave — leave the anger within you, leave the negativity in your heart, and go help him
- The Gemara learns: if you have two people to help and can only help one — prefer the person you don't get along with → to work on removing animosity

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When Anger IS Appropriate — Spiritual Matters

The Principle

אף שתכונה הכרחית היא בעניינים התלויים ברצונותינו... אין הדבר כן בעניין הדת

- When it comes to **personal matters** → always be calm
- When it comes to **spiritual matters** → sometimes you must show anger and displeasure

כל תלמיד חכם שאינו נוקם ונוטר כנחש אינו תלמיד חכם

- Any Talmid Chacham who doesn't take revenge like a snake = not a Talmid Chacham
- **Resolution:** לא קשיא — הא במילי דעלמא הא במילי דשמיא
- Personal matters → don't take revenge
- Spiritual matters → a person must stand up

Moshe Rabbeinu — The Model

When Moshe did NOT get angry (personal matters):

- The leaders said "Hashem should punish you" after conditions worsened in Egypt → Moshe didn't get angry, went back to Hashem and said: "Help them, they're right"
- Eldad and Medad prophesied outside the plan → Yehoshua ran to Moshe upset → Moshe said: המקנא אתה לי ומי יתן כל עם ה' נביאים — "If only everyone had such enthusiasm"

- Miriam spoke derogatorily about Moshe → she was punished with tzara'at → Moshe still prayed for her: אל נא רפא נא לה

When Moshe DID get angry (spiritual matters):

- The Golden Calf → ויחר אף משה וישלך מידיו את הלוחות — threw the tablets
- The sons of Elazar and Itamar didn't eat the chatat properly → Moshe got angry (even though they were later proven right)
- The war against Midian → soldiers kept the girls alive against Hashem's command → Moshe got angry

The pattern: Personal → forgo. Spiritual → stand up.

Other Examples of Righteous Anger

- **Pinchas** — killed Zimri and Cozbi for public immorality → rewarded with priesthood
- **Shmuel** — cursed Shaul for not killing Agag/Amalek as commanded → executed Agag himself
- **Shaul** — decreed death on Yonatan for eating during the fast (spiritual matter, even his own son)
- **David** — ordered the death of the man who claimed to kill Shaul (even though David benefited) and Rechab and Baanah who killed Ish-Boshet
- **Shlomo** — killed his brother Adoniyahu for rebelling against the monarchy
- **Eliyahu** — killed 450 false prophets of Baal → קנא קנאתי לה' — "I was zealous for Hashem"
- **Elisha** — spoke harshly to King Yehoram for being an idol worshipper

Note on Eliyahu and Pinchas: Some Midrashim say they're the same person. Rabbi Avraham says either way the point stands — if the same person, it's another example of Pinchas' zealotry; if different, you have two examples.

The Chachamim on Righteous Anger

- **Shammai** — was very strict in religious matters. Chachamim say don't be like Shammai — but you see he stood up for what was right
- **Rav Kahana** — killed an informer who was going to endanger Jewish lives by reporting to the authorities. Rav told him: flee to Bavel
- The Gemara says: האי צורבא מרבנן דרתח אורייתא הוא דקמרתח ליה — "When a Chacham seems angry, it's the Torah burning within him"
- The Mishnah: הוי עז כנמר... וגבור כארי לעשות רצון אביך שבשמים — sometimes you need to be bold like a leopard and strong like a lion

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Critical Qualifications

1. Not Everyone Should Be Telling People Off

מי שרחוק מלכפות חובות התורה על זולתו... אסור לצאת מגדר סבלנות

- If you don't know how to do it properly → stay out of it
- If it's not your responsibility → stay out of it
- If you don't have a relationship with the person → stay out of it

- **The Chatam Sofer on הוכח תוכיח את עמיתך:** "amitecha" = your friend. You can't rebuke someone unless you have a relationship first. Create the relationship → only then can you influence.

2. Even When Appropriate — Show Anger, Don't BE Angry

- The Rambam in Mishneh Torah and Moreh Nevuchim: when you need to discipline or rebuke → show yourself as angry, but remain fully in control internally
- Your intellect still runs the show
- You're acting angry — not being angry

3. On Balance — Calmness Should Far Outweigh Anger

אפילו בענייני הדת לא ימהר למקום להעניש אלא לאחר בירור אורך רוח וחקירה ודרישה

- Even in spiritual matters → don't rush to punish
- Investigate thoroughly first
- Even with avodah zarah (the worst sin): ודרשת וחקרת ושאלת היטב — investigate, interrogate, ask well
- Hashem's attributes: more are about mercy than judgment → so should ours be
- A person who gets angry at everything → it's not genuine
- A person who never gets angry → also not good
- **True character:** doesn't get angry about personal matters, but stands up for spiritual matters

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Does Hashem Get Angry?

The Answer: No — It's a Borrowed Expression

כי לא תחול בו מידת הכעס ולא מידה אחרת

- Hashem is above feelings — any mature understanding of God doesn't allow for God to "get angry"
- Whenever Torah says ויחר אף ה' → it means Hashem is about to **punish**
- The Radak (Rabbi David Kimchi) on the pasuk: "They think they're making Me angry — but they're only punishing themselves"

Proof: הניחה לי ויחר אפי בהם

- After the Golden Calf, Hashem says to Moshe: "Allow Me to get angry and destroy them"
- If Hashem were truly angry → He wouldn't ask permission
- When you're angry, you don't say "please allow me to get angry" — you just get angry
- Therefore: הניחה לי ויחר אפי = הניחה לי ואכלה אותם = "Allow Me to punish them"
- **Proof from Devarim (Parshat Eikev):** When Moshe retells the story, he says הרף ממני ואשמידם — "Leave Me alone and I will destroy them" — **no mention of anger at all**
- This confirms: "anger" was never the point — punishment was

The Principle

דיברה תורה כלשון בני אדם — The Torah speaks in human language

- Every time Torah uses "anger" about Hashem → it means punishment/retribution

- The Rambam explains this at length in the Moreh Nevuchim and Mishneh Torah

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Key Takeaways — Full Chapter 6 Summary

1. **Calmness ≠ apathy.** It means having feelings but being in control of them.
2. **Training Method 1:** Meditate on stories — both negative (anger → destruction) and positive (calmness → reward).
3. **Training Method 2:** Think about the mitzvot designed to prevent anger — arei miklat, tochachah, lo tikom, not cursing, not hitting, helping enemies.
4. **Personal matters → always be calm.** Spiritual matters → sometimes you must stand up.
5. **The Moshe model:** Never angry for himself. Always angry for Hashem's honour.
6. **Not everyone should rebuke.** Only if you have the ability, responsibility, AND relationship.
7. **Even when showing anger → remain in full control.** Show anger, don't be angry.
8. **On balance → calmness should far outweigh anger.** Investigate thoroughly before acting.
9. **Hashem doesn't "get angry"** — it's a borrowed expression meaning punishment. We should aspire to the same: when we "get angry" for spiritual matters, it's really about standing up for what's right.

Next Chapter

- **Chapter 7:** ענוה — Humility (the longest chapter yet — expected 3–4 classes)

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